

We've been tight for near on 25 years—two country boys who grew up studying (sometimes), working at the local Safeway (a bit), and playing footy (a lot).

Yet Matt's life took a J-walk in his early twenties when he moved to Tokyo to teach English. He fell in love with, and later married, a Japanese woman. (I was dutifully the MC at their wedding. I do not speak Japanese, and by the end of the night I barely spoke English . . . but that's a story for another time.)

Fast forward to today: Matt is living in downtown Tokyo and we both have sons roughly the same age. The cool thing about little kids is that they're basically the same regardless of nationality. Our boys may be half a world away, and growing up in very different cultures, but they like toy trucks, piggyback rides, and inappropriately loud fart noises (the universal language of dads).

But there's one thing that's very different about Japan:

Mealtimes.

When I last visited him, Matt explained this strange classroom concept the Japanese call 'the honourable mealtime'.

The story goes that after the devastation of World War II the Japanese government decided their only hope to repair their shattered country was to make education and healthy food a priority for all Japanese students.

It has worked amazingly well.

To this day very few Japanese kids brown-bag their lunch—instead schools cook nutritious meals, sourced from local ingredients. And the proof is in the tofu—Japan has the lowest obesity levels and one of the highest life expectancies on the planet.

So let's focus on the honourableness of Japanese school meals.

Here's their drill:

Each day a bell rings, and the teachers leave the classroom. That's the cue for students (kids in primary school) to put on their white coats and cute